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ARTICLE

The Surprising Link Between Modern America And Ecclesiastes



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BY PNW STAFF JUNE 01, 2026

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America has a problem, and it runs far deeper than a lack of entertainment.

A new national survey found that nearly half of Americans say the fun has disappeared from their lives. Financial pressures, exhausting schedules, work demands, and burnout are leaving millions feeling drained, disconnected, and unable to enjoy life the way they once did.



How I Lost Fatty Liver Weight

Doctor's 5 words explained my weight gain: You might have fatty liver.

At first glance, this may sound like a lighthearted story about recreation and leisure. But beneath the surface lies something much more profound. What Americans are experiencing is not simply a shortage of fun—it is increasingly a shortage of meaning.

The survey of 5,000 adults found that 48% believe their lives are seriously lacking in fun, while more than half say it is harder to enjoy life today than it was a decade ago. Cost was the most frequently cited obstacle, followed by packed schedules, work obligations, and burnout.

Those findings should not surprise anyone paying attention to modern life.

Americans today are working longer hours, carrying heavier debt burdens, battling inflation, worrying about housing costs, navigating political division, and living under a constant barrage of digital noise. Smartphones keep us connected to everyone yet somehow leave many feeling more isolated than ever before.

We are surrounded by entertainment but starving for fulfillment.



For decades, society promised that happiness could be found through greater wealth, more possessions, better experiences, bigger homes, and endless convenience. Yet despite unprecedented technological advancement, record access to entertainment, and more ways to amuse ourselves than any generation in history, millions are reporting a growing sense of emptiness.

That contradiction should cause us to stop and ask an uncomfortable question:

What if the problem isn't that we don't have enough fun?

What if the problem is that we've lost sight of why we're here?

This is hardly a new struggle.

Nearly 3,000 years ago, King Solomon wrestled with the very same issue. Possessing wealth, power, influence, pleasure, knowledge, and every earthly opportunity imaginable, Solomon embarked on a quest to discover what would truly satisfy the human heart.

His conclusions fill the pages of Ecclesiastes.

Again and again he uses the phrase "meaningless" to describe the pursuits people often chase in hopes of finding fulfillment. Wealth was meaningless. Pleasure was meaningless. Accomplishments were meaningless. Human wisdom by itself was meaningless. Even great projects and personal achievements ultimately failed to satisfy.

Solomon writes:

"Meaningless! Meaningless! Everything is meaningless."

Many modern readers misunderstand Ecclesiastes as a depressing book. In reality, it is a brutally honest examination of life when God is removed from the center.

Solomon had everything the modern world tells us to pursue, yet he found himself asking the same questions millions of Americans are asking today.

Why am I still dissatisfied?

Why does success not feel as fulfilling as I expected?

Why does life seem repetitive and empty?

Why does happiness disappear so quickly?

The answer Solomon ultimately arrives at is simple but profound.



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Human beings were not created merely to consume experiences.

We were created to know God.

The conclusion of Ecclesiastes comes at the very end of the book:

"Fear God and keep His commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."

In other words, purpose is not something we invent. Purpose is something we discover in relationship with our Creator.

That does not mean Christians never experience burnout, stress, or difficult seasons. Life remains challenging. Bills still need to be paid. Work still needs to be done. Responsibilities do not magically disappear.

But there is a tremendous difference between carrying burdens with purpose and carrying burdens without it.

When purpose disappears, even enjoyable things begin to lose their appeal.

This may help explain why so many Americans feel trapped despite living in a culture saturated with entertainment. More streaming services, more social media, more vacations, more gaming, more shopping, and more distractions have not solved the problem because the deeper need was never entertainment in the first place.

The human soul craves significance.

It longs for relationships that matter. It longs for community. It longs for truth. It longs for something bigger than itself.

Interestingly, one of the most revealing findings from the survey was that 89% of respondents said shared experiences strengthen relationships. That should not be overlooked.

God designed people for connection—not merely digital interaction, but genuine community. Families gathered around dinner tables. Friendships built through shared experiences. Churches worshiping together. Neighbors helping neighbors.

Many of the institutions that once provided meaning, belonging, and purpose have weakened dramatically in recent decades. Church attendance has fallen. Civic organizations have declined. Families are increasingly fragmented. Social isolation has risen.

As those foundations erode, people often attempt to replace them with entertainment. But entertainment can distract from loneliness; it cannot cure it.

The survey found that participants believed they would need an additional 17 hours each week to restore balance to their lives.

Yet perhaps the solution is not merely finding more hours.

Perhaps it is rediscovering what those hours are for.

The growing "fun deficit" may actually be a symptom of a much larger spiritual deficit. People are not just exhausted. They are searching. They are looking for purpose in a culture that increasingly struggles to explain why life matters at all.

Ecclesiastes reminds us that life under the sun—life lived apart from God—will eventually leave us empty. But life lived in fellowship with our Creator transforms even ordinary moments with meaning.

The answer to America's growing dissatisfaction may not ultimately be found in more vacations, bigger paychecks, or better entertainment options.

It may be found in the same place Solomon discovered it thousands of years ago.

Not in chasing the next experience.

But in returning to the One who gives every experience its purpose.

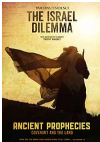
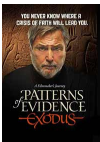
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